



ASSIGNMENT OF MARKETING

Topic: Positioning for Competitive Advantage, Positioning Strategies & Positioning Errors

Brand: Shan Foods (Shan Masala)



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Question No. 1 – Product Position Analysis

Explain the product position of your selected brand. How is the brand perceived by consumers relative to its competitors?

Shan Foods is positioned as Pakistan's most authentic and trusted spice mix brand that brings the true taste of traditional Pakistani and South Asian cuisine into every home. The brand has successfully created a unique identity in the food category by focusing on recipe authenticity, convenience, and international quality standards.

1. Overall product position:

Shan's product position can be understood as:

- Authentic, region-specific spice blends (Biryani, Karahi, Nihari, etc.)
- Ready to use masala mixes that save time without compromising taste
- A brand that represents home cooking and cultural food heritage

The brand emphasizes traditional recipes, carefully measured spices, and consistent taste, which differentiates it from basic curry powders or loose spices. Its products include over 100 different recipe mixes, ranging from meat dishes to vegetarian options, all designed to deliver restaurant quality taste at home.

Consumers perceive Shan not just as a masala brand, but as a guarantee of delicious, fail proof cooking.

2. Consumer perception:

In the minds of consumers, Shan is associated with:

- **Authenticity:** Customers believe Shan recipes come from traditional kitchens and regional experts. Each package tells a story of origin.
- **Consistency:** Every time a consumer uses Shan Biryani mix, the taste is exactly the same. This reliability builds deep trust.
- **Convenience:** Shan eliminates the need to buy ten different spices separately. One packet does everything.

- International Standards: Shan is also popular among overseas Pakistanis because it is available globally and meets food safety standards.

As a result, the brand is highly popular among home cooks, working women, and expatriate Pakistanis who want authentic taste without spending hours in the kitchen.

3. Position relative to competitors:

When compared with its major competitors, Shan occupies a premium and authentic position:

- Brand Position in Market Comparison with Shan
- National Foods Convenience focused, slightly milder taste Less bold in flavor; more generic
- Mehran Affordable, basic spice mixes Lower price but also perceived as lower quality
- Lazica Regional specialty, limited variety Niche player, not a national competitor
- Local unbranded masalas Cheap, inconsistent quality No trust or quality assurance
- Shan is seen as the market leader in terms of taste authenticity and brand trust.

Question No. 2 – Competitive Advantage Analysis

Identify and explain any two competitive advantages of the brand. Discuss whether these advantages are based on Product, Service, Channel, People, or Image.

Shan Foods has developed strong competitive advantages that help it dominate Pakistan's spice mix market. Two of its most significant advantages are based on Product and Image.

1. Product based competitive advantage:

Shan's primary competitive advantage lies in its extensive, authentic, and tested recipe library.

Shan has invested decades in researching traditional recipes from different regions of Pakistan and South Asia. Each spice mix is developed by food scientists and chefs to ensure the perfect balance of flavors. Unlike competitors who offer generic masalas, Shan offers region specific products such as:

- Sindhi Biryani Mix
- Lahore Karahi Mix
- Peshawari Chaplin Kebab Mix
- Multani Sohan Halwa Mix

This level of specialization is not easily replicated by competitors. Furthermore, Shan uses high quality spices with no artificial colors or harmful preservatives in many of its products.

Why it is a Competitive Advantage:

- Customers trust Shan to deliver authentic regional tastes that other brands cannot copy.
- The variety (over 100 products) covers almost every Pakistani dish, making Shan a one stop solution.
- Competitors like National Foods have fewer product variants and less regional specificity.

2. Image based competitive advantage:

Another key strength of Shan is its brand image of trust, tradition, and international acceptance. Shan has built a powerful image through decades of consistent marketing. Its iconic green and red packaging, the smiling chef logo, and the tagline “Khaykin Bhi aur Chalayan Bhi” (Eat and also serve others) are deeply embedded in consumer

memory. Shan is also one of the few Pakistani food brands available in over 100 countries, which reinforces an image of quality and reliability.



Why it is a Competitive Advantage:

- The strong image reduces perceived risk. A new cook will choose Shan because it is a known, trusted name.
- International availability makes Shan a source of pride for Pakistanis abroad, creating emotional loyalty.
- Competitors like Mehran or local brands lack this premium, global brand image.

Question No. 3 – Positioning Strategy

Identify the primary positioning strategy used by the brand and justify your answer with examples. Possible strategies include: Product Features & Benefits Positioning, Price–Quality Positioning, Competitive Positioning, User Positioning, Corporate Brand Positioning, Leveraging Existing Brand Strategy.

Primary Positioning Strategy of Shan Foods:

Product Features & Benefits Positioning:

Shan primarily positions itself by emphasizing the unique features and functional benefits of its spice mixes.

1. Explanation of the strategy:

Product Features & Benefits Positioning means the brand highlights specific attributes of the product (features) and translates them into advantages for the customer (benefits). Shan does this masterfully:

- Feature: Recipe developed from traditional regional experts.
- Benefit: Authentic taste that matches homemade or restaurant quality.
- Feature: Pre measured blend of multiple spices.
- Benefit: Convenience and consistency. No need to buy separate spices or guess quantities.
- Feature: No added colors or harmful preservatives.
- Benefit: Safe and healthy cooking for family

2. Justification with examples:

Example 1 – Biryani Mix Packaging: On the back of every Shan Biryani box, there is a clear explanation: “Contains red chili, cumin, coriander, cardamom, cloves, and 12 other spices.” Then it states the benefit: “Gives authentic Sindhi biryani taste in 30 minutes.” This is direct product features and benefits communication.

Example 2 – TV Commercials: Shan advertisements often show a home cook struggling to get the perfect taste, then using Shan masala and succeeding. The voiceover says: “Shan ka secret? 15 masala ka perfect blend.” (Shan’s secret? Perfect blend of 15 spices.) No mention of price discounts or competitions. Only the product feature and the benefit of great taste.

Example 3 – Social Media Campaigns: Shan regularly posts recipe videos on Instagram and YouTube. Each video highlights a specific product, shows the ingredients list (feature), and demonstrates how easy it is to cook a delicious meal (benefit).

3. Why this strategy works for Shan:

- It differentiates Shan from generic loose spices that have no quality guarantee.
- It builds trust because customers can see exactly what they are buying.
- It appeals to both experienced cooks (who value authenticity) and beginners (who value convenience).

Advertisement/Promotional Evidence:

A clear example of this positioning strategy can be seen in Shan's digital campaign "Shan Kay Saath Khana Banega Aasan" (Cooking becomes easy with Shan). On Shan's official Facebook page and YouTube channel, short videos show the exact spice mix being opened, poured into a pan, and the final dish being served. The caption always includes both the feature (special blend of 12 spices) and the benefit (restaurant taste at home).



Question No. 4 – Principles of Effective Positioning

Evaluate the brand using any two of the following principles: Relevance, Clarity, Distinctiveness, Coherence, Commitment, Patience, Courage. Provide practical examples to support your evaluation.

Shan Foods can be effectively evaluated using the principles of Relevance and Coherence, as these two principles strongly explain the brand's enduring success.

1. Relevance:

Relevance means how well a brand's positioning aligns with the needs, preferences, and expectations of its target market. A brand is effective when it offers value that customers actually care about.

Shan demonstrates strong relevance because it understands the priorities of Pakistani consumers:

- Taste is the highest priority: Pakistani home cooks care more about authentic taste than price. Shan delivers authentic regional flavors.
- Convenience matters: Working women and busy mothers need quick cooking solutions. Shan's readymade mixes save time.
- Trust in tradition: Consumers trust brands that respect cultural cooking heritage. Shan's recipes come from traditional kitchens.

Practical Examples:

- Ramadan Campaigns: During Ramadan, Shan runs special campaigns for Iftar dishes (samosas, pakoras, chaat). These are highly relevant because families cook more during this month and need easy solutions.
- Overseas Pakistani Focus: Shan is available in Walmart, Carrefour, and Amazon in the UK, USA, and Middle East. For Pakistanis living abroad who crave home food, Shan is the most relevant brand because it provides authentic taste with locally available ingredients.

This shows that Shan's products are highly relevant because they directly match customer cooking habits, cultural preferences, and lifestyle needs

2. Coherence:

Coherence means all aspects of the brand's marketing mix (product, price, place, promotion) work together to deliver the same consistent message. A brand is effective when there is no contradiction between what it says and what it does.

Shan demonstrates strong coherence because every element supports the same positioning of "authentic, convenient, trustworthy spice mixes."

Practical Examples:

- Product matches promise: Shan claims authentic recipes, and indeed each product has a distinct regional taste.
- Packaging matches message: The green and red packaging with traditional motifs reinforces the idea of heritage and freshness.
- Price matches positioning: Shan is priced higher than National Foods or Mehran, which is coherent with its premium authentic image. If Shan were cheap, customers would doubt the quality.
- Distribution matches brand: Shan is available everywhere – from small Kiyana shops to high end supermarkets. This coherence ensures that even rural customers access the same authentic product.
- Advertising matches product: Shan ads never show western dishes. They always show biryani, karahi, nihari – traditional Pakistani food. This coherence strengthens the brand's credibility.

Because of this coherence, customers never feel confused about what Shan stands for. The brand's message is consistent across all touchpoints.

Question No. 5 – Positioning Errors

Analyze whether the brand faces any of the following positioning errors or risks: Under positioning, Over positioning, Confused Positioning, Doubtful Positioning, Irrelevant Positioning. Explain which error is most relevant (or potentially relevant) to the brand and provide justification.

Shan Foods generally has a very strong and clear positioning. However, it faces a potential risk of Over positioning, which is the most relevant positioning error for the brand.

Error: Over positioning

Over positioning occurs when a brand is perceived too narrowly by consumers, limiting its appeal to a specific segment. For Shan, the risk is that it is seen only as a masala for heavy, meat based Pakistani dishes, which might alienate health-conscious consumers or those looking for lighter cooking options.

Why over positioning is relevant to Shan:

Shan is overwhelmingly known for products like Biryani Masala, Karahi Masala, Nihari Masala, and Chaplin Kebab Masala. These are rich, spicy, and often high in oil and salt. While this is a strength for traditional cooking, it creates limitation

1. Perception as unhealthy or heavy:

Many health-conscious consumers, especially younger generations and fitness enthusiasts, believe that Shan masalas are too spicy, too salty, or not suitable for daily cooking. They perceive Shan as a “special occasion” brand rather than an everyday brand

Example:

A person trying to eat low sodium or low oil meals may avoid Shan entirely, thinking all products are equally heavy. In reality, Shan also has lighter products like Chaat Masala, Chole Masala, and Fish Fry Masala, but these are not as famous.

2. Limited appeal for non-meat dishes:

Shan has many vegetarian and poultry products, but consumers still associate the brand strongly with beef and mutton dishes. This narrow perception can hurt sales to vegetarians or people who prefer chicken and vegetables.

Example: A vegetarian customer looking for a good Chana Masala might not even check Shan because they think “Shan is for biryani and karahi only.”

3. Generational gap:

Younger Pakistanis who grew up abroad or prefer fusion cooking (e.g., pasta, wraps, grilled chicken) may find Shan irrelevant because they see it as “traditional” and “heavy.” This is a classic over positioning problem – the brand is so strongly tied to one cooking style that it misses new trends.

- Under positioning: No, consumers know exactly what Shan is.
- Confused positioning: No, Shan has a very consistent message.
- Doubtful positioning: No, customers have no reason to doubt Shan’s taste claims.
- Irrelevant positioning: No, authentic taste is highly relevant to Pakistani consumers.

Conclusion:

In conclusion, Shan’s main positioning risk is over positioning, as it is strongly perceived as a brand for heavy, meat based, traditional Pakistani dishes. While this has made it a leader in that category, it may limit its appeal to health-conscious consumers, vegetarians, and younger generations looking for lighter or fusion options. Shan can reduce this risk by promoting its lighter products (e.g., Fish Masala, Chole Masala, Chaat Masala) more aggressively and by introducing lower sodium or “everyday light” variants under a sub brand.